possibly in a far more meaningful way than the edicts. The basic point is that Ashoka's voice in Girnar would have been seen as one element, albeit singular in content, of a broad constellation of Mauryan interventions, creating in their totality the groundwork of power within which state pronouncements were received and interpreted.

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While Girnar had an impressive lineage of connections with the Maurya monarchs, there was something that the emperor had spoken about earlier at various places from the outcrops of Andhra to the rocks beyond the Ganga which was missing in this much more magnificent setting. At Girnar the full set of major edicts had been engraved to create one long sermon. The overall impression here is of an emperor doubling as spiritual preacher, holding forth on matters at variance with local religious rites and practices. But the populace here was not privy to what the Erragudi people knew. There, via his minor rock edicts, Ashoka had specified that his metamorphosis had a Buddhist basis before he spoke at length about all kinds of other matters in the major rock edicts engraved there; at Girnar there is no evidence of his new religion in his edicts.

This lack of specification does not mean the local people would not have known about Ashoka's religious conversion. Traces that remain in the immediate hinterland of ancient Junagadh and Girnar point to the possibility that this was common knowledge which probably did not need to take up precious rock space. In several parts of India the epigraphs had been positioned in the vicinity of early Buddhist monuments. At such spots there were early stupas and temples ('chaityas'). These were either known or likely to have been constructed with Ashoka's patronage. Knowledge of the king's conversion will surely have travelled out from such places.